



ROUTEUP CAREER GUIDANCE SERIES — VOLUME 3

The Real Cost of Studying Abroad

Budgets, Loans, and the ROI Question Families Skip

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The Number Nobody Calculates

Families calculate tuition. Almost nobody calculates the full cost of being alive in another country for two to three years — and that second number is what breaks budgets, forces desperate part-time work, and sends students home early.

Myth: “Tuition is the main cost.”

Reality: In many destinations, living costs across the course period equal or exceed tuition. Accommodation alone in Australian cities runs around A\$250 per week — even for shared rooms — and rent there is paid weekly, not monthly.

Myth: “I’ll cover my expenses with a part-time job.”

Reality: Part-time work is a bonus, never a plan. If your ability to eat and pay rent depends on finding work in your first months, you are travelling under-funded. Visa officers know this too — thin finances are the #1 documented reason for refusals.

Myth: “An education loan is just a formality.”

Reality: A ₹40 lakh loan repaid over 15 years can approach ₹1 crore in total repayment. The loan outlives the degree by a decade. Know the total repayment figure — not the sanctioned amount — before you sign.

Build Your Real Budget

For your target city (not country — city), research current figures for every line:

- Rent (note the payment cycle — weekly in Australia/NZ, monthly in most of Europe/North America)
- Utilities, internet, and mobile
- Groceries and food (cooking vs eating out changes this 3x)
- Transport (student passes vs car dependence — US suburbs often force a car)
- Health insurance (mandatory in most destinations, often payable upfront: e.g. UK health surcharge £776/year, Australia OSHC for full course duration)
- Course extras: books, lab fees, professional memberships
- One flight home + emergency buffer (minimum 3 months of living costs)

The financial documentation trap

Visa officers reject applications showing sudden large deposits just before applying, unclear sponsor relationships, or funds that barely scrape the minimum. Build a 6-month organic banking history and keep a 20–30% buffer above the stated requirement. Money that appears overnight reads as borrowed-for-show — because it usually is.

What consultancies won't tell you: 'show money' arrangements — borrowing funds briefly to fatten a bank statement — are visa fraud. When detected, they don't just sink this application; they can poison every future application to that country. Anyone offering to 'arrange' your financials is selling you a lifetime ban.

Worksheet — Your Family's Real Numbers

- ☐ Total tuition for full course: _____
- ☐ Realistic living cost per month × course months:

- ☐ One-time costs (visa, insurance, flights, deposits):

- ☐ TOTAL project cost (sum of the above): _____
 - ☐ Loan amount needed: _____
 - ☐ Total repayment over full tenure (ask the bank for this figure in writing):

 - ☐ Realistic starting salary in my field, in that country:

 - ☐ Years to repay at that salary while living there:

 - ☐ My funds have a 6-month organic history with no sudden deposits
 - ☐ I have a buffer of at least 20–30% above the official financial requirement
 - ☐ I can survive 12 months with zero part-time income
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When to Get Help

Everything in this volume you can act on yourself — that is deliberate. But the worksheet you just filled has answers only YOU could write, and validating those answers against real requirements, real budgets, and real immigration rules is where mistakes hide.

Bring your completed budget worksheet to session with RouteUp. We will go through it line by line and tell you honestly — including if your plan is fine and you don't need us further.

Book your free session: www.routeup.co.in · hello@routeup.co.in

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